

Archive Health Tool

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Overview

How do you measure and improve the quality of an archive? Milli Archives Foundation (MAF) is developing an open-access Archives Health Tool (AHT) for archives across India to self-evaluate along a set of parameters, and work with a benchmarking model that allows them to strengthen their work on an area of their choice. To shape and advise this work, Milli is drawing on the input of 20 member archives from across India.

Survey of Archives in India (Part 1 of 2): <https://bit.ly/milli-aht-survey1>

Survey of Archives in India (Part 2 of 2): <https://bit.ly/milli-aht-survey2>

Survey of Archives in India (for users): <https://bit.ly/milli-aht-user-survey>

Project Website: <https://milli.link/aht>

Contact email for collaboration and queries: hello@milli.link

Intent and Motivation

The Milli Archives Foundation is working on the first draft of a detailed survey to assess archives. We aim to work with the Milli Member Network to refine the tool and take it for a test-drive in person and during visits to various archives. Archives are rarely ever evaluated in India, and even if they were, there are close to no metrics to do this. Should an archive measure itself based on the structure of its archival material? Perhaps it wishes to be sized by its workflows and policies. Should it look at diversity in its sourcing or uses, or both? How does it balance the rights of various constituents: creator, donor, community, archive, funder, researcher, audience? Is public engagement central to the archives as commons, as third place? How does one place increasing diversity in all measures? The Archives Health Tool will be available for every archive, big and small, to assess and improve as they see fit. We hope the public will also nudge archives toward trying the tool out to improve their favourite archive, and get us all closer to archives.

The project is the first of its kind in India, and a free tool to benefit every memory institution – whether it is a personal almirah, or a state archive.

Archive Health Tool Components

The archive health tool that has been developed by Milli has three components — the survey linked below, a benchmarking and evaluation process (work in progress), and the creation of a roadmap (work in progress) for the concerned archive in collaboration with Milli.

Survey and Links

The survey developed is intended as a self-assessment for archives and their users. Based on this, Milli will conduct the evaluation and initiate the benchmarking process. The survey is split into three parts:

Survey of Archives in India (Part 1 of 2): <https://bit.ly/milli-aht-survey1>

Survey of Archives in India (Part 2 of 2): <https://bit.ly/milli-aht-survey2>

Survey of Archives in India (for users): <https://bit.ly/milli-aht-user-survey>

The first part of the survey is meant to get a basic understanding of the archive, from an archive builder's point of view. The first section contains questions on the type of archive that is filling the survey. Sections such as "Acquisitions" and "Collections" are meant to understand more about the content of the archives and the theme of the collections. "Metadata and Catalogues", "Physical Infrastructure" and "Storage and Physical Organisation" are intended as a way for Milli to understand the description and arrangement of the items in the archive, as well as the physical space that they are kept in. Lastly, the "Utilities" section covers basic amenities available to the staff and users.

The second part of the survey is meant to get a better understanding of the personnel involved with the archive as well as its engagement with external parties such as the general public. The section, "Staff and skills", for instance, covers issues such as employment conditions. Sections like "Inclusion" and "Accessibility" cover populations that might sometimes be excluded from an archive.

These two surveys together take approximately two hours to fill.

While the user survey contains many of the same sections as the builder survey, there are some key differences between the two. Certain questions, especially those on funding and organization within the archive, have been removed as it is unlikely that users of an archive are aware of this information. Additionally, some questions, such as those on utilities and access, have been modified to get the impression of an outsider going through the process of accessing an archive as part of their research, rather than an employee who oversees these processes regularly. Both perspectives are required in order to make an informed assessment of an archive.

The user survey takes approximately 20-30 minutes to fill.

Benchmark and Evaluation

The second step in the measurement of archival health by Milli's tool is an evaluation, followed by benchmarking conducted by Milli. Responses to the survey are analysed by the Milli team, following which a meeting is held with the archive in order to discuss the responses. Milli is developing a benchmarking process in order to offer baseline standards across various parameters and allow a surveyed archive to benchmark themselves among other archives in the country. We believe this will help them understand their strengths and weaknesses.

The surveys are intentionally kept anonymous. Archives that wish for Milli to get in touch with them for this purpose can include their email IDs when filling their information in the surveys.

Roadmap for Archives

The Archive Health Tool proposes a potential roadmap for surveyed archives. This will be based on the survey responses, evaluation and subsequent benchmarking, intended to provide a checklist to archives on what actions to take in order to strengthen desired areas. The intention is for the archive to follow this roadmap, following which it can circle back to taking the survey again in the future. This allows archives to have defined metrics and leads to a cycle of continuous improvement. To our knowledge, there is no precedent for this in archives in India. Accreditation and evaluation projects for archives do function in other parts of the world, including the Archive Service Accreditation led by the National Archives of the UK (<https://www.nationalarchives.gov.uk/archives-sector/archive-service-accreditation/>). For comparison with other disciplines, the Commonwealth Higher Education Management Service report on higher education benchmarking practices provides measures for institutions that conduct self-evaluations in four-year cycles.

Process History

Milli Archives Foundation is a non-profit company dedicated to building, nurturing and sustaining archives in India. In 2024, within a few months of its formal establishment, it started working on compiling a directory of archives. This was to be the first step towards our objective of nurturing archives. The directory was to be dynamic with information being added continuously. Neetu Kumari, research assistant engaged by Milli, compiled a spread sheet of 110 different archives and their types, based on publicly accessible information.

Very soon, through interactions with others in the profession, the objective was further refined and what was planned initially as a directory of archives in India was modified to be an assessment of different types of archives on various parameters and toward the development of a benchmarking tool. The assessment was to be undertaken either in person or using websites of different archives. The work was taken up by Alolika Sutradhar, a research assistant at Milli, who developed the first draft survey form for assessment of various types of archives. This project included the survey of a private papers archive at a university and a religious

institution archive: the Ashoka Archives of Contemporary History of India, based on information publicly available on their website, and an in-person visit to Ramakrishna Mission Vivekananda Ashrama, Raipur. The survey gave an insight into the bulk, collections, archives acquisition, management, users, care and conservation, building, digitization, staff and overall outlook of the archives. These internal documents helped shape the project further, and led to the first test of a survey form.

The survey form was refined in 2025 by Jaya Ravindran and Shreyasi Pathak for the purpose of sharing it with the Milli Member Network at Milli Sessions 2025 (Jun 12-14, 2025, CEPT University, Ahmedabad). The survey at this point was a single form to be used by archive builders (archivists, conservators, archival assistants, research assistants, and others). Following detailed discussions, further amendments were made and the survey form for archives was divided into two parts. Daya Ambirajan, researcher for Milli, incorporated the changes suggested in Milli Sessions 2025 and on behalf of Milli, shared it with the network members for their inputs. Following their responses, Daya Ambirajan continued work on refining this survey, as well as creating a separate survey for the users of the archive.

Methodology for Survey

Past Initiatives and Background Research

Many organizations, whether collectives of archivists or governments, have carried out archive assessment surveys and produced archive improvement tools and checklists worldwide. In 1989, the Society of American Archivists (SAA) put together a workbook titled *Archives Assessment and Planning Workbook* (McCarthy 1989). This workbook lists the various areas and activities that an archive may carry out, functioning as a checklist when assessing one's archive. *A Guide for Surveying Archival and Records Management Systems and Services: A RAMP Study* (Evens and Ketelaar, 1983) is another example of such an endeavour, including a survey with multiple sections of questions regarding the functioning of an archive. In 2002, the Council for Museums, Archives and Libraries (UK) produced *Benchmarks in Collections Care for Museums, Archives and Libraries*, which is a comprehensive checklist spanning several key activities carried out by cultural institutions. It includes areas such as policy, storage, emergency preparedness, conservation, handling and usage of materials, and more. In 2012, Institute of Museum and Library Services (IMLS), based in the USA, published the *Self-Assessment Tool for Museums, Libraries and 21st Century Skills*, a matrix meant to aid in self-assessment of cultural institutions. It describes the different levels in quality and functioning of cultural institutions across various fields such as collections care, human capital, physical space and more. It uses a three-point scale to describe the levels of effectiveness, describing what each level would look like for each field.

More recently, in 2022, the Northeast Document Conservation Center (NEDCC) published a leaflet detailing how an archive might conduct an assessment of its needs through in-house as well as external sources. This leaflet is limited to the preservation activities that archives carry

out. In April 2026, the UK government Department for Culture, Media and Sport published an assessment report containing data across various performance indicators provided by UK museums and galleries. The performance indicators included Access, Audience Profile, Learning and Outreach, and more.

Two user surveys were consulted in the making of Milli's Archive Health Tool User Survey. The *National Archives and Records Administration Customer Satisfaction Survey Report* (NARA, 2018) is an analysis of questions asked to the users of the National Archives (USA) along with their results in graph form. The *Survey of Visitors to Archives* (2022) conducted by the Archives & Records Association (ARA) surveyed around 5000 archive users on their experiences using archives, supplementing these queries with questions on their purpose and research background.

While these surveys are comprehensive and have been very useful in our thinking about an archive health tool for archives in India, Milli believes that the Indian archiving environment is at times different from those in the countries of origin of the above surveys. Archival material in India is present in a variety of media and languages, and many archives are at a state of extreme neglect. Furthermore, Indian climate conditions vary from region to region, making an all-encompassing standard for document storage difficult. Lastly, the amount of funds received via grants for Indian private archives might not cover the varied types of environmental controls that they may need. These points make the Indian archival field unique, necessitating a unique form of assessment.

In India, the IGNCA conducted a survey of archives in the country (*Mapping of Archives in India*, 2023), compiling a list of archives complete with contact information and qualitative information on the functioning of the archives. This survey was useful in order to gain an understanding of similar initiatives conducted in the country, as well as to procure a list of archives in the country available to participate in the Milli survey and benchmarking process. Building on this work, Milli decided to increase the level of detail of the survey, including more questions covering a wide range of activities carried out by Indian archives.

The Archive Health Took Survey for Archive Builders

The first draft of the survey was shared in the internal working group of the Milli Member Network at the Milli Sessions 2025 (Jun 12-14, 2025, CEPT University, Ahmedabad). This was a single survey at this point, to be filled by archive builders (archivists, conservators, archival assistants, research assistants, etc.). During the Milli Sessions, Milli Member Network archives were able to contribute to the form as a collective by giving feedback on its efficacy as an assessment tool. Feedback was given concerning the length, the question types and additional parameters of archive assessment that were relevant.

Following these Milli Sessions, the Milli Archives Foundation worked together with Daya Ambirajan to further refine the survey. To make the survey more manageable, we decided to split it into two parts, to facilitate an easier and more comfortable experience of filling it.

The first part of the survey consists of the following topics:

- Introduction to Archive
- Acquisitions
- Collections
- Legislations and Guidelines
- Metadata and Catalogues
- Physical Infrastructure
- Storage and Physical Organisation
- Utilities

The second part of the survey consists of the following topics:

- Staff and Skills
- Community Archives
- Website
- Digitization
- Digital archives
- Accessibility
- Inclusion
- Outreach

The sections on community archives and digital archives were added after feedback stating that different kinds of archives must be represented in the questionnaire. Further, an “additional questions” section was added at the end of the survey. This includes questions regarding priorities for an archive, since not every archive may find all aspects of the survey relevant to their work. The intention of this section is to enable Milli to analyse the responses and suggest a potential roadmap based on the individual needs of the archive, rather than a more generalized view of what archives should be. We felt that this input was necessary, as the Member Network, as well as the larger network of archives in the country, consists of institutions of various sizes, types and budgets. In order to cater the roadmap to each archive’s specific needs, the priorities of the individual archive are an important piece of information.

These two forms, intended for the builders of archives, were sent out in December 2025 and 13 responses were received by the end of January 2026. These early respondents helped shape the survey further.

The Archive Health Took Survey for Archive Users

The second survey type is intended for users of archives. This helps us get a full picture of the functioning of an archive, as the users of archives will be able to provide their perspective on the accessibility, utilities and user-friendliness of an archive they accessed or visited for their research. The user survey was based on the builder surveys and questions were modified to suit informed users. Additionally, users were given two choices – either they could fill up the

detailed survey, consisting of multiple sections, or they could fill out an open-ended free text question on their impression of the archive that they were assessing.

The sections that formed the user survey are as follows:

- Introduction to user
- Introduction to assessed archive
- Legislations and guidelines
- Registration and fees
- Access and duplication
- Website
- Physical Infrastructure
- Utilities
- Accessibility
- Finding Aid + Catalogue
- Collections
- Additional Questions

The user survey was first tested in March 2026 on a group of six archive users, who were selected for their diverse professional backgrounds. Following this, the survey was sent to the archives that are part of the Milli Member Network, requesting them to send the form to their users, which would then add to the data provided by them via the builder survey.

Methodology for Benchmark

The second part of the Archive Health Tool is a benchmarking system for archives in India. This is work in progress.

The benchmarking module would entail locating the archive within the general archival environment in India based on the areas that were assessed in the surveys, serving as a snapshot summary of where the specific archive stands in a particular parameter, in relation to other comparable archives. It would also serve as a tool for archives to assess themselves in comparison to their performance in previous assessments, acting as a measure for improvement, if needed.

Globally, while several assessment surveys for cultural institutions such as archives and museums have been formulated and carried out (briefly summarized above), there have been very few observable initiatives to locate individual archives within a broader context and assist them with road-mapping based on their priorities. One such initiative is the Facility Issues initiative, which is a commercial initiative based in New York that carries out yearly group benchmarking sessions, placing institutions on a graphically represented scale for various parameters such as the environmental sustainability of the institution. Furthermore, it helps institutions identify their strengths and weaknesses so that they can plan future improvements to their facilities.

While the above initiative is a quantitative approach that employs scoring and graphing institutions' performance, Milli decided to proceed with a qualitative approach to benchmarking. Due to the diversity in the social, physical and financial environments of the archives that submitted responses to the survey, comparing them on a numerical scale would mean losing a significant amount of nuance. For instance, one archive that submitted their response had 25 employees, whereas another had just two. The functioning and output of these archives would be different, and they cannot be compared using a single scale without losing this critical information. Over time, as the survey responses grow, we expect to be able to develop a more quantified benchmarking system, especially after there are sufficient datapoints for each type of archive.

Additionally, a study on the benchmarking of higher education institutes was used as a reference point (*Benchmarking in higher education: a study conducted by the Commonwealth Higher Education Management Service*). In the first attempt at a benchmarking system, the researcher used an "activity-based approach" as outlined in the above material. This was a qualitative approach, seeking to analyse each archive's performance in the various "activities" performed by an archive (delineated using the survey sections). Owing to the detail-oriented nature of the approach, however, concerns were raised about it being time consuming, and the methodology is currently still being refined.

Methodology for Roadmap

The third part of the Archive Health Tool is the development of a roadmap for an archive, based on its survey responses and benchmarking assessment. This is work in progress.

As a start, following their submission of survey responses, Milli contacted the Roja Muthiah Research Library (RMRL), Chennai, to test the process of analysing the survey responses and suggesting a possible roadmap in order to improve the functioning of the archive. First, we prepared an analysis of RMRL's response to the survey, identifying potential strengths and weaknesses in their functioning across the spectrum of areas as listed above. A list of suggestions was prepared along with this analysis. Then, we met with RMRL's team for this discussion. As it is impossible to thoroughly ascertain an archive's priorities through the survey alone, the read-through and discussion of the analysis in a meeting provided an invaluable resource to further refine the list of suggestions as well as the questionnaire itself. In this meeting, the archive was able to clarify its position with regards to the theme of the collection, the storage conditions, the employee welfare policies and many other areas.

Additionally, the meeting brought the need for a specific question on the priorities of each individual archive. One of the challenges of setting up an archive in India is the wide variation in climate, language and nature of material, and disproportionately low funding, among other things. As a result, every archive operates on a set of vastly different priorities. For example, the RMRL library prioritizes activities such as cataloguing and digitization, over other

interventions that may be more expensive and not a good fit for their local environment. We envision that a roadmap would be tailored to foreground specific priorities of archives.

Future Directions

This report details the initial efforts towards the formation of the Archival Health Tool, with a launch of the first component, the survey tools, and an outline of the follow-up components of benchmarking and road-mapping.

The next step for the project is a concrete approach to benchmarking. A disadvantage to qualitative benchmarking is the requirement for detail. This could be time consuming and one risks erring on the side of being too granular, thus losing out on a summarizing nature that is otherwise inherent to a benchmarking process. However, using a solely quantitative approach to benchmarking in such a diverse archival background could result in an unrealistic comparison between archives that work at different scales and resources, and with different audiences or needs. We envision identifying a balance between a quantitative and qualitative approach for the benchmarking module, with an attempt to bring in a mix of granular detail and pattern-recognizing assessment metric.

Between 2014-2016, an initiative under the name of OpenGLAM conducted a benchmark survey among the GLAM (galleries, libraries, archives, museums) sector worldwide, seeking to understand the extent to which institutions around the globe were engaging with open access practices. This included the crowdsourcing of annotations, free exchange of information, exchange of metadata and several other parameters. While a question on public annotations to archival objects is included in the questionnaire, a potential future direction for the Archive Health Tool survey module could be to understand the attitudes Indian institutions have towards open access archival practices.

References (Chicago Manual of Style)

Archive & User surveys and assessment tools

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Specific parameters

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Conceptual

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Acknowledgements

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Archive of IIT Madras, Indian Institute of Technology Madras
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